

an issue. Manufacturers are not able to invest in new equipment, most of which is imported.

Survey participants also mention that lifespan of the typical PCB manufacturing equipment used today is a maximum of four years, after which these tend to become redundant.

Infrastructural challenges such as insufficient clean water and uninterrupted power, a limited number of developed industrial parks and lack of an ecosystem for raw materials are some hindrances for the PCB industry. There is also a need for huge investments in creating and maintaining effluent treatment facilities, which is one of the major challenges for this industry.

Growing inorganically

More than half of the survey participants believe that inorganic growth can play a major role in this segment (Fig. 4), either through mergers and acquisitions or through joint ventures. Survey participants who spoke positively about inorganic growth feel that, since most manufacturers in the country find it challenging to make huge investments required to produce PCBs for high-tech products like set-top boxes and mobile handsets in large volumes, any kind of partnership with foreign companies could help Indian firms manufacture high-tech PCBs via technology transfer.

Moving forward

Despite limitations like an inefficient supply chain, capital-intensive nature of the industry, low investment-to-sales ratio, and logistics and infrastructural issues, the Indian PCB industry should be able to witness sustainable growth if the government can provide a level playing field. Survey respondents feel that the industry does not need nurturing or subsidies. Instead, the government should be a catalyst for growth. They cite the example of the Indian automotive industry where the government discourages automotive imports with its high duty structures and complicated registration processes, which is compelling automotive companies to manufacture in India, resulting in a proper manufacturing ecosystem. Similar models can be replicated for PCBs and other electronic components as well.

Given that there is a huge domestic demand for electronic products, such a move will help not just the PCB industry but the entire electronics ecosystem to achieve long-term sustainable growth in line with the government's Make in India initiative. **EFY**



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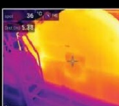


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